

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 103 “HOLINESS AND SANCTIFICATION”

Course Description: This course explores holiness as the essential nature of God and the divine calling of the believer in Christ. Students examine the biblical doctrine of holiness and sanctification through theological, exegetical, historical, pastoral, and practical perspectives. Emphasis is placed on the holiness of God, positional and progressive sanctification, consecration, purity, spiritual warfare, victorious Christian living, the ministry of the Holy Spirit, holiness in Church history, and the role of holiness in Christian ministry. The course aims to cultivate spiritual maturity, Christlike character, and a deeper understanding of Spirit-formed living within the believer and the Church.

Part One:

The Nature of Holiness and God’s Call to a Holy Life

The Meaning of Holiness in Scripture

Holiness is one of the most misunderstood doctrines in the Church, often reduced either to moral strictness or to cultural rules. In Scripture, however, holiness is far deeper than behavior. Holiness first describes God’s nature, before it ever describes human conduct.

The word “holy” in both Hebrew and Greek fundamentally means set apart, distinct, or other. When Scripture declares God to be holy, it is not merely stating that God is morally pure; it is declaring that God is wholly other, incomparable, and unique in His being. God is not simply the best among many; **He is in a category by Himself.**

Isaiah encountered this reality in his vision of God, where the seraphim cried, “*Holy, holy, holy, is the LORD of hosts: the whole earth is full of his glory*” (Isaiah 6:3). The threefold repetition emphasizes intensity and completeness. God is holy in essence, holy in character, and holy in action.

Holiness, therefore, is not something God possesses; it is what God is. Every attribute of God: His love, mercy, justice, and power; is holy because it flows from His holy nature.

God’s Holiness as the Standard of All Life

Because God is holy, everything that truly belongs to Him must reflect His holiness. Scripture makes this connection unmistakably clear. God says, “*I am the LORD your God: ye shall therefore sanctify yourselves, and ye shall be holy; for I am holy*” (Leviticus 11:44).

This statement establishes the foundation of biblical sanctification. Holiness is not defined by human opinion, cultural norms, or religious tradition. It is defined by God

Himself. God does not call His people to be holy according to their capacity, but according to His nature.

Peter carries this same truth directly into the New Testament, writing, *“As he which hath called you is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation; because it is written, Be ye holy; for I am holy”* (1 Peter 1:15–16).

This continuity shows that holiness is not an Old Testament burden removed by grace. It is a timeless expression of God’s will for His people.

Holiness Before It Is Moral, Is Relational

One of the great errors in teaching holiness is starting with rules instead of relationship. Scripture does the opposite. Holiness begins not with conduct but with belonging.

God first separates a people unto Himself, then calls them to live in a way that reflects that separation. Israel was holy not because they behaved better than other nations, but because God had chosen them and set them apart. **Their conduct was meant to flow from that reality. The living of a believers supposed to flow from their faith (Jesus).**

God says plainly, *“I am the LORD that doth sanctify you”* (Leviticus 20:8). Sanctification is first God’s work, not man’s effort.

This same order applies under the New Covenant. Believers are called saints: holy ones, not because they have arrived at perfection, but because they have been set apart in Christ. Paul writes, *“Unto the church of God which is at Corinth, to them that are sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints”* (1 Corinthians 1:2).

Notice the tense: sanctified: already done. Holiness begins with identity before it ever becomes practice.

New Birth and Holiness

Holiness is impossible without the New Birth. A dead spirit cannot produce holy life. This is why Scripture never commands unbelievers to live holy lives; it calls them first to be born again.

When a person is regenerated, a new principle of life is introduced. This new life carries a new orientation toward God. Holiness is therefore not an external imposition but an internal inclination.

Paul explains this transformation when he writes, *“If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new”* (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Holiness is not the attempt to polish the old life; it is the outworking of a new life. The believer does not pursue holiness to become accepted by God; the believer

pursues holiness because they have been accepted.

Sanctification: Set Apart Unto God

The word “sanctification” is closely related to holiness and carries the idea of being set apart for God’s purpose. In Scripture, to sanctify something means to remove it from common use and dedicate it wholly to God.

Jesus prayed for His disciples, “*Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth*” (John 17:17).

Here sanctification is shown as an ongoing process by which believers are increasingly aligned with God’s truth and purposes.

Sanctification has both:

- a definitive aspect (what God has already done), and
- a progressive aspect (what God continues to do in the believer’s life).

Hebrews captures this tension beautifully: “*For by one offering he hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified*” (Hebrews 10:14).

Believers are already sanctified in Christ, yet they are also being sanctified in daily life. This is not contradiction; it is the dynamic nature of salvation.

Holiness is not optional for the believer, nor is it reserved for a special class of Christians. Scripture speaks with sobering clarity: “*Follow peace with all men, and holiness, without which no man shall see the Lord*” (Hebrews 12:14).

This verse does not teach salvation by works, but it does teach that genuine salvation produces a holy trajectory. Where there is no pursuit of holiness, the reality of regeneration must be questioned.

Holiness is not perfectionism, but it is direction. It is not sinless living, but it is sincere devotion. It is not external conformity, but inward alignment with God’s will.

Part Two: Positional and Progressive Sanctification, and the Inner Conflict

The Two Dimensions of Sanctification in Scripture

Sanctification in the Bible operates in two inseparable dimensions: what God has already accomplished in Christ, and what God is continually working out in the believer’s life. Failing to hold these two together leads either to legalism or to careless living.

First, Scripture speaks of sanctification as a completed act. This is often called positional or definitive sanctification. By virtue of union with Christ, the believer is set apart unto God once and for all. Paul writes, *“But ye are washed, but ye are sanctified, but ye are justified in the name of the Lord Jesus, and by the Spirit of our God”* (1 Corinthians 6:11).

Notice the past tense. Sanctification here is not presented as a goal to be achieved, but as a reality already established. This sanctification is not based on the believer’s maturity but on Christ’s finished work. God claims the believer as His own and separates them from the dominion of sin.

Hebrews reinforces this truth by declaring, *“By the which will we are sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all”* (Hebrews 10:10). Sanctification, in this sense, is as secure as the cross itself.

Yet Scripture also speaks of sanctification as an ongoing process. This is progressive sanctification: the daily transformation of the believer’s life into conformity with Christ. Paul exhorts believers, *“This is the will of God, even your sanctification”* (1 Thessalonians 4:3), and later prays, *“The very God of peace sanctify you wholly”* (1 Thessalonians 5:23).

These exhortations would be meaningless if sanctification were only positional. Progressive sanctification addresses growth, obedience, and the practical outworking of holiness in everyday life.

The Role of the Holy Spirit in Sanctification

Sanctification is not accomplished by human willpower but by the active work of the Holy Spirit. Scripture consistently presents the Spirit as the agent of holiness in the believer.

Paul writes that believers are chosen *“through sanctification of the Spirit”* (2 Thessalonians 2:13). The Spirit applies the work of Christ, reshaping desires, renewing the mind, and producing holy affections.

The Spirit does not merely restrain sin; He produces righteousness. Galatians 5 describes this clearly. While the works of the flesh arise naturally from fallen humanity, the fruit of the Spirit emerges from divine life within. Love, joy, peace, self-control, and righteousness are not manufactured virtues; they are the evidence of the Spirit’s sanctifying presence.

This is why sanctification cannot be reduced to rule-keeping. External discipline without internal transformation leads to hypocrisy. True holiness flows from life in the Spirit.

The Conflict Between Flesh and Spirit

One of the most realistic aspects of biblical sanctification is its acknowledgment of inner conflict. Scripture does not deny struggle; it explains it.

Paul describes this tension vividly: *“For the flesh lusteth against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh: and these are contrary the one to the other”* (Galatians 5:17).

The flesh, in biblical terms, does not merely refer to the physical body. It refers to the fallen human nature, the patterns of thought, desire, and impulse that remain even after regeneration. The presence of conflict does not mean the absence of holiness; it often indicates its presence.

Romans 7 records Paul’s honest struggle with indwelling sin. This passage is not a denial of sanctification but a testimony to its reality. The believer now hates what they once loved and desires what they once ignored. This internal war is evidence of new life.

Victory in this struggle does not come through self-effort but through walking in the Spirit. Paul concludes, *“If ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body, ye shall live”* (Romans 8:13).

The Means God Uses in Progressive Sanctification

God employs specific means to sanctify His people. One primary means is the **Word of God**. Jesus prayed, *“Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth”* (John 17:17). As Scripture renews the mind, it reshapes values, exposes sin, and aligns the believer with God’s will.

Another means is **obedient faith**. Sanctification advances as the believer responds to God’s grace with submission. This obedience is not legalistic compliance but loving response. Jesus said, *“If ye love me, keep my commandments”* (John 14:15).

God also uses **discipline and correction**. Hebrews explains that God disciplines His children not as punishment, but as training: *“He chastens us for our profit, that we might be partakers of his holiness”* (Hebrews 12:10).

Even trials become instruments of sanctification when received in faith. Suffering strips away self-reliance and deepens dependence upon God.

Biblical holiness avoids two extremes. Legalism seeks holiness through human effort and external regulation. It produces pride, judgment, and exhaustion. License, on the other hand, abuses grace by denying the call to transformation. It produces complacency and spiritual decay.

Scripture rejects both. Paul asks, *“Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound? God forbid”* (Romans 6:1–2). Grace does not excuse sin; it breaks sin’s dominion.

True holiness is grace-empowered obedience. It rests in Christ while actively pursuing conformity to Him.

Part Three:

The Pursuit of Holiness in Spiritual Warfare and Victorious Christian Living

Holiness and Spiritual Warfare

One of the greatest misunderstandings in modern Christianity is the assumption that spiritual warfare is primarily about power encounters while neglecting the necessity of holiness. Scripture, however, consistently presents holiness itself as a dimension of spiritual warfare. Satan opposes holiness because holiness reflects God's nature, weakens the dominion of sin, and establishes the believer in spiritual authority.

From the beginning, Satan's rebellion was fundamentally a revolt against divine order and submission. His fall was not caused by weakness but by corruption within. Ezekiel writes concerning him, "Till iniquity was found in thee" (Ezekiel 28:15). Sin entered the realm of creation through pride, self-exaltation, and rejection of God's holy order. Spiritual warfare therefore is not merely external conflict with demonic powers; it is the ongoing conflict between God's holy purposes and every force that opposes them.

Paul makes this reality explicit when he writes, "For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world" (Ephesians 6:12). Yet significantly, before Paul discusses spiritual weapons, he first addresses righteous living, truth, faith, obedience, and purity. The armor of God is deeply moral before it is militant.

The "breastplate of righteousness" is not symbolic decoration; it represents the protective power of a life aligned with God's will. Persistent compromise weakens spiritual sensitivity and opens doors to bondage, accusation, and deception. Satan is called "the accuser of the brethren" (Revelation 12:10) because condemnation thrives where sin is tolerated.

Holiness therefore is not legalistic restriction; it is spiritual protection.

Throughout Scripture, impurity is often connected to spiritual oppression. This does not mean every struggle is caused by demons, but Scripture clearly teaches that sinful patterns create vulnerability. Paul warns believers in Ephesians 4:27, "Neither give place to the devil." The word "place" implies territory, opportunity, or foothold. Unforgiveness, lust, bitterness, pride, rebellion, and deception become openings through which spiritual darkness operates.

This explains why sanctification is inseparable from deliverance. God does not merely cast out darkness; He transforms the life so darkness no longer finds agreement within the heart.

James establishes the divine order of victory: "Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you" (James 4:7). Notice that resistance to Satan is ineffective without prior submission to God. Authority over darkness flows from alignment with divine holiness.

Many seek spiritual power while neglecting spiritual purity, yet Scripture never separates authority from consecration. The sons of Sceva attempted spiritual warfare without covenant relationship and were overcome by demonic power (Acts 19:13–16).

Spiritual authority is not derived from formulas but from union with Christ and submission to His lordship.

The warfare against sin is also internal. The believer contends not only with external temptation but with the remnants of fallen desires within the flesh. Peter exhorts believers to “abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul” (1 Peter 2:11). Sin is not passive; it wages war against spiritual vitality.

For this reason, holiness requires vigilance. Jesus instructed His disciples, “Watch and pray, that ye enter not into temptation” (Matthew 26:41). Temptation itself is not sin, but unguarded temptation becomes fertile ground for sin’s growth.

The believer’s victory over sin is rooted not in self-confidence but in the superior power of the Holy Spirit. Paul declares, “Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh” (Galatians 5:16). The Spirit empowers believers not merely to avoid evil, but to desire righteousness.

True spiritual warfare therefore is not measured merely by dramatic encounters with demons, but by increasing conformity to Christ. Every victory over pride, lust, bitterness, greed, fear, rebellion, and deception is evidence of the triumph of divine holiness within the believer.

A believer who walks in holiness becomes difficult for darkness to manipulate because light exposes what darkness depends upon. Holiness sharpens discernment, strengthens prayer, preserves spiritual sensitivity, and deepens communion with God.

Victory in spiritual warfare is ultimately Christ-centered. Jesus triumphed over Satan not merely through displays of power but through perfect obedience. In the wilderness temptation, Christ answered every assault of Satan with submission to the Word of God (Matthew 4:1–11). Where Adam failed through disobedience, Christ conquered through holiness.

The cross itself was the decisive victory over the kingdom of darkness. Colossians declares that Christ “spoiled principalities and powers” and “made a shew of them openly, triumphing over them in it” (Colossians 2:15). Sanctification therefore is the progressive outworking of Christ’s victory within the believer’s life.

Holiness is not withdrawal from battle; it is preparation for battle. The sanctified believer becomes spiritually stable, discerning, resistant to deception, and increasingly effective in prayer and ministry.

The Church must recover the understanding that purity is power. Throughout Scripture, God consistently entrusted spiritual authority to consecrated vessels. Holiness does not earn God’s presence, but it preserves sensitivity to His presence.

A generation that seeks manifestations without sanctification will eventually collapse under the weight of corruption. But a people formed in holiness become carriers of divine authority in a darkened world.

Satan fears holiness because holiness reproduces the image of Christ in believers, and every life conformed to Christ becomes a visible announcement of Satan's defeat.

Victorious Christian Living and the Daily Pursuit of Holiness

The Christian life was never intended to be a cycle of continual defeat, recurring bondage, and powerless religion. Salvation in Christ is not merely the forgiveness of sins; it is also liberation from the dominion of sin. Scripture declares, "Sin shall not have dominion over you: for ye are not under the law, but under grace" (Romans 6:14). The believer may still struggle, but the believer is no longer a slave.

Victorious Christian living does not mean the absence of temptation, weakness, or spiritual conflict. Rather, it refers to a life progressively governed by the Spirit instead of by sinful desires. Victory is not sinless perfection, but increasing dominion through union with Christ.

One of the central truths of sanctification is that the believer's identity has fundamentally changed. Paul repeatedly emphasizes that believers are no longer who they once were. "Ye were sometimes darkness, but now are ye light in the Lord" (Ephesians 5:8). The Christian does not fight for acceptance before God; the Christian fights from acceptance already secured in Christ.

Many believers struggle because they attempt holiness through self-effort instead of through spiritual dependence. The flesh cannot produce righteousness, regardless of how disciplined it appears outwardly. Paul asks the Galatians, "Having begun in the Spirit, are ye now made perfect by the flesh?" (Galatians 3:3). Sanctification begins by grace and continues by grace.

Grace, however, is often misunderstood. Biblical grace is not permission for compromise; it is divine empowerment for transformation. Titus teaches that "the grace of God that bringeth salvation... teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, we should live soberly, righteously, and godly" (Titus 2:11–12). Grace not only pardons the believer; it trains the believer.

Victory over sin therefore involves cooperation with the work of the Holy Spirit. Paul commands believers to "put off concerning the former conversation the old man" and to "put on the new man" (Ephesians 4:22–24). Sanctification requires intentional surrender. While holiness is empowered by God, it must also be actively pursued by the believer.

This pursuit includes the renewing of the mind. Many sinful patterns persist because the mind remains shaped by worldly values, desires, and imaginations. Paul writes, "Be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind" (Romans 12:2). Transformation occurs as the Word of God reconstructs the believer's thinking according to divine truth.

The battle for holiness is often a battle for the mind. Thoughts shape desires, desires influence actions, and repeated actions form character. Satan frequently attacks through deception because distorted thinking produces distorted living. This is why

believers must learn to “bring into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ” (2 Corinthians 10:5).

Prayer also occupies a central place in victorious Christian living. Prayer is not merely a religious exercise; it is communion with God and dependence upon divine strength. Jesus instructed His disciples, “Watch ye and pray, lest ye enter into temptation” (Mark 14:38). A prayerless believer becomes spiritually vulnerable because victory cannot be sustained apart from intimacy with God.

The Word of God likewise serves as a weapon against temptation. Jesus overcame Satan in the wilderness through unwavering submission to Scripture, repeatedly declaring, “It is written” (Matthew 4:4–10). The believer who neglects Scripture weakens spiritual discernment and becomes more susceptible to deception.

Fellowship and accountability are also means of preservation in holiness. Christianity was never designed to be lived in isolation. Hebrews exhorts believers to “consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works” (Hebrews 10:24). Sin thrives in secrecy, but spiritual growth flourishes in godly community.

Practical holiness must extend into every dimension of life. Holiness is not confined to church activities or public spirituality. Scripture repeatedly connects holiness to speech, relationships, conduct, finances, sexuality, integrity, and private character.

Paul commands believers, “Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth” (Ephesians 4:29). Words reveal the condition of the heart. A sanctified life gradually produces sanctified speech.

Holiness must also govern sexual conduct. In a world that celebrates immorality, Scripture calls believers to purity. Paul writes plainly, “This is the will of God, even your sanctification, that ye should abstain from fornication” (1 Thessalonians 4:3). Sexual purity is not repression; it is the honoring of God with the body.

The believer’s relationship with material possessions is likewise affected by sanctification. Greed, covetousness, and dishonesty contradict the spirit of holiness. Scripture teaches contentment, stewardship, generosity, and integrity as expressions of godly character.

Even digital life and media consumption fall under the call to holiness. What believers consistently watch, celebrate, meditate upon, and entertain shapes spiritual appetite. Paul exhorts, “Whatsoever things are pure... think on these things” (Philippians 4:8). The mind cannot continually feast on corruption and remain spiritually healthy.

Victorious Christian living also requires perseverance after failure. Even sincere believers stumble at times. The difference between the righteous and the rebellious is not the absence of failure but the response to failure. “A just man falleth seven times, and riseth up again” (Proverbs 24:16). Conviction from the Holy Spirit leads the believer back to repentance and restoration.

Satan often seeks to imprison believers in condemnation after failure, but Scripture distinguishes conviction from condemnation. Conviction draws the believer toward

God; condemnation drives the believer away from Him. Romans 8:1 declares, “There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus.”

The believer’s confidence ultimately rests not in personal consistency but in Christ’s sustaining grace. Jude closes with this assurance: God “is able to keep you from falling, and to present you faultless before the presence of his glory with exceeding joy” (Jude 24).

Victorious Christian living is therefore neither passive nor self-reliant. It is a daily yielding to the Spirit, a continual dependence upon grace, and an ongoing transformation into the likeness of Christ.

Holiness is not merely avoiding evil; it is increasingly delighting in God.

The goal of sanctification is not merely that believers stop sinning, but that they become so possessed by the beauty of Christ that sin gradually loses its attraction.

Part Four:

Holiness in Church History and Holiness in Ministry

Holiness Movements in Church History

The pursuit of holiness did not begin with modern Christianity, nor is it limited to a particular denomination or movement. Throughout the history of the Church, believers in every generation have wrestled with the call to purity, consecration, and deeper conformity to Christ. Although different eras expressed holiness in different ways, the central burden remained the same: the people of God must reflect the character of the God they worship.

In the Early Church, holiness was closely connected to discipleship, suffering, and separation from pagan culture. The first Christians lived in a world saturated with idolatry, immorality, and emperor worship. To confess Christ publicly often meant persecution, rejection, and death. Holiness therefore was not merely private morality; it was visible allegiance to Jesus in the midst of a hostile society.

The writings of the early Church fathers consistently emphasized purity of life, obedience to Christ, and faithfulness under suffering. Martyrdom itself was viewed as the ultimate testimony of devotion to Christ above worldly compromise. The Church understood that holiness carried a cost.

As Christianity later became more culturally accepted after the conversion of Emperor Constantine, some believers feared that spiritual seriousness was declining within the Church. In reaction, many pursued radical devotion through what became known as monasticism. Men and women withdrew into deserts and isolated communities to pursue prayer, fasting, discipline, and separation from worldly corruption.

While some expressions of monasticism became unhealthy or excessively ascetic, the movement reflected a sincere desire for wholehearted devotion to God. The monks

recognized an important truth: intimacy with God requires separation from distractions and compromise.

During the medieval period, however, portions of the Church increasingly drifted into ritualism and institutional corruption. Holiness was often reduced to external religious practices rather than inward transformation. Yet even in spiritually dark periods, God continually raised voices calling the Church back to purity and repentance.

The Protestant Reformation of the sixteenth century restored central truths concerning salvation by grace through faith. Reformers such as Martin Luther and John Calvin powerfully emphasized justification by faith and the authority of Scripture. However, the Reformers also taught that genuine faith produces transformed living. Salvation was never presented as mere intellectual belief detached from holiness.

Following the Reformation, the Puritans emerged with a deep concern for practical godliness. The Puritans were not content with doctrinal correctness alone; they desired the transformation of the whole life. They emphasized prayer, family worship, personal devotion, moral integrity, and seriousness about sin.

For the Puritans, holiness was not legalistic performance but the outworking of genuine communion with God. They understood that theology divorced from godliness produces spiritual pride rather than spiritual maturity.

In the eighteenth century, the holiness emphasis became especially prominent through the ministry of John Wesley. Wesley taught strongly on sanctification and the believer's pursuit of holy living. While some later interpretations of Wesley's teachings became extreme, his central burden was deeply biblical: Christianity must involve real transformation, not merely religious profession.

Wesley emphasized disciplined spiritual living, accountability, prayer, evangelism, and practical righteousness. The Methodist revival produced widespread moral reform and spiritual awakening because it united evangelism with the pursuit of holiness.

Out of this tradition emerged the nineteenth-century Holiness Movement, which stressed consecration, purity, and entire devotion to God. Many within this movement desired a deeper experience of sanctification and victory over sinful living. Although some teachings became imbalanced, the movement helped recover the Church's awareness that grace was meant to transform conduct as well as forgive sin.

The Keswick Movement later contributed another important emphasis by teaching the believer's absolute dependence upon Christ for victorious living. Its central message was often summarized in the phrase: "Let go and let God." Though sometimes oversimplified, the movement rightly emphasized that sanctification is ultimately the work of divine grace rather than fleshly striving.

The Pentecostal movement of the twentieth century also emerged with a strong emphasis on holiness. Early Pentecostal believers understood that the power of the Holy Spirit was inseparable from consecrated living. Prayer, purity, fasting, repentance, and separation unto God were foundational elements of Pentecostal spirituality.

Unfortunately, in some modern expressions of Christianity, holiness has gradually been replaced either by entertainment-driven religion or by superficial spirituality focused only on external success. In certain circles, power is pursued without character, gifting without purity, influence without integrity, and manifestations without transformation.

Yet throughout Church history, one truth remains consistent: every genuine move of God has carried a renewed emphasis on holiness.

Revival and holiness are inseparable companions. Whenever God draws near to His people, sin becomes exceedingly sinful, repentance becomes sincere, and consecration becomes necessary. Isaiah cried, “Woe is me!” when he encountered the holiness of God (Isaiah 6:5). True encounters with God always expose the need for purification.

Church history repeatedly demonstrates that spiritual decline begins when holiness is abandoned. Corruption in leadership, compromise in doctrine, and moral collapse often emerge gradually when the fear of God diminishes within the Church.

At the same time, history also warns against distorted forms of holiness. Some movements reduced holiness to outward appearance, cultural restrictions, or legalistic regulations while neglecting inward transformation. Biblical holiness must never be reduced merely to dress codes, external rules, or performative spirituality.

Jesus rebuked the Pharisees precisely because they appeared righteous outwardly while remaining corrupt inwardly (Matthew 23:27). Genuine sanctification transforms both the heart and the conduct.

The study of holiness movements in Church history therefore teaches two important lessons. First, the call to holiness has always remained central to authentic Christianity. Second, holiness must remain rooted in grace, truth, and relationship with Christ rather than in mere externalism.

The Church does not need a new definition of holiness; it needs a renewed vision of the holiness of God.

Every generation that loses the fear of God eventually redefines holiness to accommodate the sins it no longer wishes to confront.

Holiness and Ministry

One of the greatest dangers in ministry is the assumption that public gifting can substitute for private holiness. Scripture consistently teaches the opposite. In the kingdom of God, character is meant to sustain what gifting attracts. Where holiness is absent, ministry eventually becomes vulnerable to corruption, pride, manipulation, and spiritual collapse.

Throughout Scripture, God places extraordinary emphasis upon the purity of those who serve before Him. Under the Old Covenant, the priests were required to undergo consecration before ministering in the sanctuary. Their garments, sacrifices, cleansing

rituals, and separations all symbolized a profound spiritual reality: those who handle holy things must not treat them casually.

Although New Covenant believers are not bound to ceremonial regulations, the principle remains unchanged. God still desires consecrated vessels. Paul writes, “If a man therefore purge himself from these, he shall be a vessel unto honour, sanctified, and meet for the master’s use” (2 Timothy 2:21).

Ministry is not merely about usefulness; it is about fitness for divine purpose.

One of the tragedies of modern Christianity is the celebration of charisma above character. Public success often receives greater attention than private integrity. Yet Scripture repeatedly warns that visible gifting can coexist temporarily with inward corruption. Jesus declared that many would prophesy, cast out devils, and perform mighty works in His name, yet still hear the words, “I never knew you” (Matthew 7:22–23).

Spiritual gifts do not necessarily prove spiritual maturity.

Samson stands as one of the clearest biblical examples of this danger. He carried extraordinary divine empowerment, yet his private life remained compromised by lust, impulsiveness, and disobedience. For a season, his gifting appeared to overshadow his weakness, but eventually his lack of consecration destroyed his strength. The tragedy of Samson was not merely that he lost power, but that he lost discernment before he lost power. Scripture says, “He wist not that the LORD was departed from him” (Judges 16:20).

A minister can continue functioning publicly while gradually deteriorating spiritually inwardly.

This is why holiness in ministry must begin with the fear of God. The fear of God is not terror of punishment but reverent awareness of divine holiness and accountability. Ministers who lose the fear of God often begin to treat sacred responsibilities casually. Familiarity with spiritual things can become spiritually dangerous when reverence disappears.

Nadab and Abihu illustrate this sobering reality. Though ordained as priests, they offered “strange fire” before the Lord contrary to His command (Leviticus 10:1–2). Their error was not merely procedural; it reflected irreverence toward divine holiness. Ministry performed without submission to God’s order becomes dangerous.

Likewise, the sons of Eli occupied sacred office while living in corruption and immorality. Though they ministered externally, they dishonored God internally. Eventually divine judgment came upon both their ministry and their household (1 Samuel 2:12–17).

These examples demonstrate that God does not evaluate ministry merely by outward activity but by inward condition.

The New Testament therefore places enormous emphasis upon the moral qualifications of spiritual leaders. In 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1, Paul outlines qualifications for overseers that focus primarily on character rather than talent. Leaders must be sober, faithful, self-controlled, blameless, hospitable, and spiritually disciplined.

Notably, Paul says little about charisma, eloquence, or popularity. This is because God's primary concern for leadership is not performance but integrity.

Holiness in ministry also involves purity of motive. It is possible to engage in spiritual work while secretly seeking personal glory, influence, recognition, or financial gain. Yet ministry that begins to exalt self rather than Christ gradually becomes spiritually corrupted.

Paul consistently guarded his motives carefully, declaring, "We preach not ourselves, but Christ Jesus the Lord" (2 Corinthians 4:5). True ministry points people toward Christ rather than building personality-centered devotion.

Humility therefore becomes essential to holiness in ministry. Pride is especially dangerous in spiritual leadership because influence can easily produce self-exaltation. The very anointing meant to glorify Christ can become corrupted when ministers begin craving admiration.

Lucifer himself fell through pride. Ezekiel declares, "Thine heart was lifted up because of thy beauty" (Ezekiel 28:17). Pride transforms gifted servants into self-centered vessels.

For this reason, ministers must continually cultivate dependence upon God. Prayer is not optional maintenance for ministry; it is the lifeline of ministry. A public ministry without private prayer eventually becomes performance rather than spiritual service.

Jesus Himself frequently withdrew to pray despite carrying perfect holiness. If the sinless Son of God prioritized communion with the Father, how much more must ministers remain dependent upon divine grace?

Holiness in ministry also requires purity in relationships. Many spiritual downfalls begin through unguarded emotional compromise, hidden immorality, manipulation, or abuse of trust. Ministers are called not merely to preach holiness but to embody it relationally.

Financial integrity likewise matters deeply before God. Scripture warns repeatedly against greed and dishonest gain among spiritual leaders. Peter exhorts shepherds to serve "not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind" (1 Peter 5:2). Ministry motivated by covetousness eventually distorts the gospel itself.

Another essential dimension of ministerial holiness is consistency between private and public life. Hypocrisy destroys spiritual credibility because people eventually discern the difference between authentic spirituality and religious performance. Paul instructed Timothy, "Take heed unto thyself, and unto the doctrine" (1 Timothy 4:16). Notice the order: first the life, then the teaching.

Doctrine without holiness produces dead orthodoxy, while ministry without integrity produces scandal and destruction.

Yet holiness in ministry must never become self-righteous isolation. Ministers remain dependent upon grace like every other believer. The pursuit of holiness is not the pursuit of flawless image management but sincere submission to Christ. Even spiritual leaders must walk continually in repentance, humility, and dependence upon the Spirit.

Ultimately, the goal of ministry is not the preservation of reputation but faithful representation of Christ. The minister is called to embody the message they proclaim.

A holy ministry becomes powerful not merely because of eloquence, gifting, or influence, but because heaven recognizes vessels that genuinely belong to God.

The greatest threat to ministry is not lack of gifting but the gradual separation of public anointing from private consecration.

Comprehensive Conclusion

Holiness, Sanctification, and the Believer's Conformity to Christ

Holiness stands at the very center of God's redemptive purpose. From Genesis to Revelation, Scripture consistently reveals a God who not only saves a people unto Himself, but also transforms them into His likeness. Salvation was never intended merely to rescue humanity from judgment; it was intended to restore humanity into communion, purity, and conformity to the image of Christ.

The holiness of God is the foundation of all true holiness. Before holiness becomes an ethical demand upon humanity, it is first the revelation of God's own nature. God is utterly pure, righteous, separate from evil, and perfect in all His ways. Every call to sanctification therefore flows from divine character. God does not call His people to an arbitrary standard; He calls them to reflect Himself.

Sin fundamentally disrupted this divine intention. Humanity's fall in Eden was not merely the violation of a command but the corruption of human nature itself. The image of God in man became distorted through rebellion, producing spiritual death, alienation, moral corruption, and bondage to sin. Fallen humanity became incapable of generating true holiness apart from divine intervention.

For this reason, holiness can never originate merely from external regulation or religious effort. Law may restrain outward behavior temporarily, but it cannot transform the inward condition of the heart. Genuine sanctification requires regeneration. The sinner must first be made alive through the New Birth before holy living can truly emerge.

Through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ, God accomplished both redemption and restoration. Christ did not merely die to forgive sinful actions; He died to break the dominion of sin itself. In union with Christ, believers are justified, sanctified, adopted, and progressively transformed by the Holy Spirit.

Sanctification therefore possesses both a definitive and progressive dimension. Positionally, believers have already been set apart unto God through Christ's finished work. Progressively, believers are continually being transformed into Christlikeness through the ongoing work of the Spirit.

This process of transformation involves spiritual warfare, daily surrender, renewed thinking, obedience to Scripture, prayer, and continual dependence upon grace. The Christian life is not passive. Holiness must be pursued intentionally, though never through self-reliance. Grace empowers what God commands.

The Holy Spirit occupies a central role in sanctification. He convicts, purifies, renews, strengthens, instructs, and produces spiritual fruit within the believer. Holiness is therefore not merely behavioral modification but the manifestation of divine life within human vessels.

Church history repeatedly confirms the centrality of holiness in authentic Christianity. Every genuine move of God has carried renewed emphasis upon repentance, purity, consecration, and spiritual seriousness. At the same time, history warns against reducing holiness to externalism, legalism, or cultural performance detached from inward transformation.

True holiness remains deeply relational. It flows from communion with God rather than from religious image management. The believer does not pursue holiness merely to appear spiritual before others, but because intimacy with God produces increasing hatred for sin and increasing love for righteousness.

Holiness also remains essential for ministry. Spiritual gifting without character eventually collapses under the weight of corruption. God seeks consecrated vessels through whom His life, truth, and power may flow without distortion. Private purity sustains public usefulness.

Ultimately, sanctification is Christ-centered. Jesus is both the model and source of holiness. He perfectly revealed the life humanity was created to live: complete obedience, complete purity, complete surrender to the Father. Through union with Him, believers are progressively being transformed into that same image.

The final hope of sanctification reaches beyond present spiritual growth into future glorification. Scripture promises that believers shall one day be completely conformed to Christ. "When he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is" (1 John 3:2). The work of holiness that begins in regeneration will ultimately culminate in eternal perfection before God.

Thus, holiness is not merely a doctrine among many doctrines. It is the destiny of redeemed humanity.

The Church must therefore recover a biblical vision of holiness: not harsh legalism, not superficial morality, not performative spirituality, but Spirit-formed conformity to Christ flowing from intimacy with God.

EDC 103

The goal of sanctification is not merely that believers behave differently, but that Christ Himself becomes visible through transformed lives.

Holiness is the gradual disappearance of the self-life so that the character, desires, and beauty of Christ become increasingly visible within the believer.

Signed:

By Discp. Samuel Ojo

EDC Rector